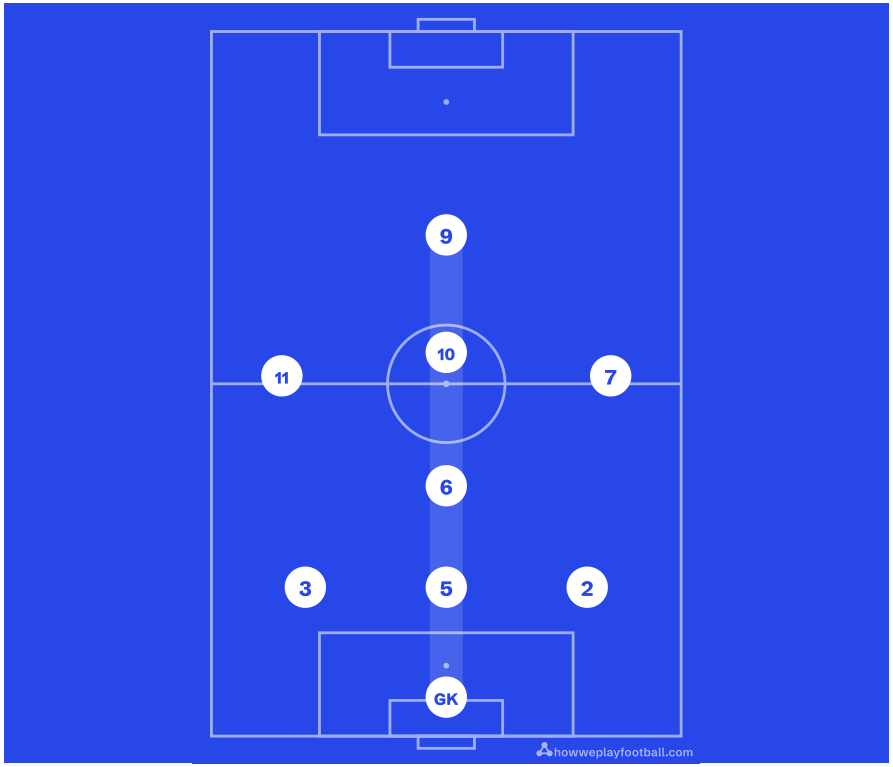
9V9 FORMATION GUIDE

3-1-3-1

A starting shape, four rules and a job for every position.



HOW TO USE THIS BOOKLET

One way of playing 9v9: where the players start, four principles everyone can remember, a job for every position and how the team plays together.

WHO IT'S FOR

Volunteer coaches of 9v9 teams, including parents new to coaching. No qualification needed.

KEEP IT IN YOUR BAG

1. Read the shape and the four principles before your session.
2. Use the position pages to give each player their job.
3. Use page 18 for quick cues during matches.

CONTENTS

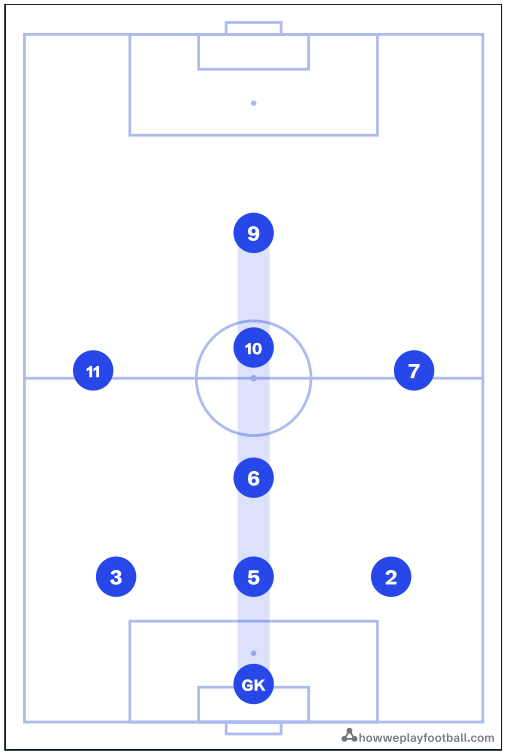
	READING THE DIAGRAMS	3
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READING THE DIAGRAMS

We always attack up the page. Each picture shows a single moment.

US	Our players, numbered by position.
THEM	The other team.
BALL	Where the ball is.
STARTED HERE	Where a player was before they moved.
RUN	A player moving.
PASS	The ball moving.
BLOCKED	A pass that is blocked, or a place not to be.
KEY SPACE	The space that matters in this moment.
GAP	A space we have left open.
✓ RIGHT ✕ WRONG	What we want, and what to avoid.
1 · 2	Steps. Read them in order.

01 STARTING SHAPE



WHO'S WHO

GK
Goalkeeper

5
Centre-back

2 · 3
Outside defenders

6
The screen

7 · 11
Wide players

10
Number 10

9
Striker

1-3-1-3-1 counts the goalkeeper first. Our spine (shaded) runs through the middle: **GK, 5, 6, 10, 9**.

THIS SHAPE GIVES US

1. THREE DEFENDERS
2. PROTECTION THROUGH THE MIDDLE
3. WIDTH ON BOTH SIDES
4. A 10 CLOSE TO THE STRIKER
5. FOUR PLAYERS WHO CAN QUICKLY JOIN AN ATTACK

THE FORMATION IS OUR STARTING POSITION. IT ISN'T WHERE WE HAVE TO STAND.

THE FOUR PRINCIPLES

01 **MIDDLE FIRST** 6
Protect the middle before chasing the ball outside.

02 **ONE GOES, ONE STAYS** 7
One outside defender can attack. The other stays.

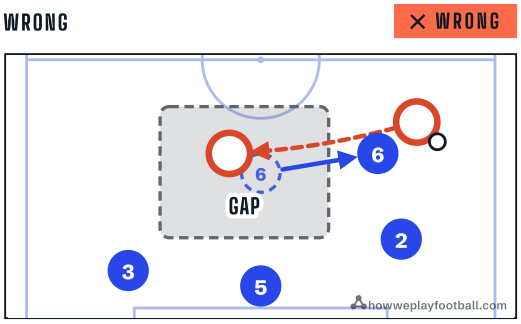
03 **FAR SIDE IN** 8
When we attack down one side, the opposite wide player attacks the goal.

04 **SHOW THEM WIDE, THEN GO** 9
Protect the middle, guide them to the touchline, then press together.

01 MIDDLE FIRST

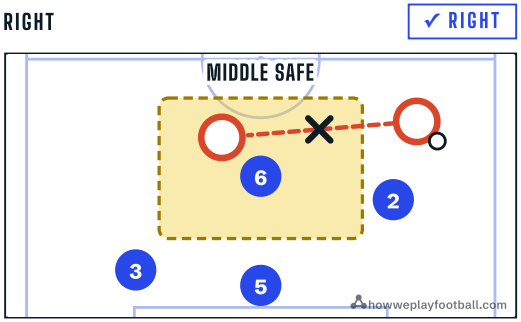
Protect the middle before chasing the ball outside.

WRONG



6 is dragged to the touchline. A big gap opens in front of 5.

RIGHT



6 stays central, between the ball and our goal. The middle is closed.

LOOK FOR

The 6 stays central, between the ball and our goal.

Nobody leaves a gap in front of the centre-back (5) to chase the ball wide.

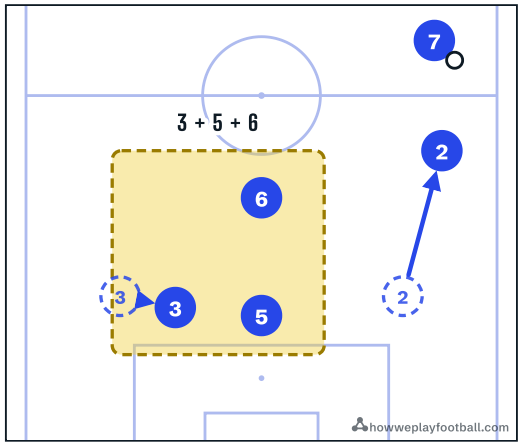
IF YOU'RE NOT SURE WHETHER TO GO, STAY CENTRAL.

02 ONE GOES, ONE STAYS

One outside defender can attack. The other stays.

BALL RIGHT

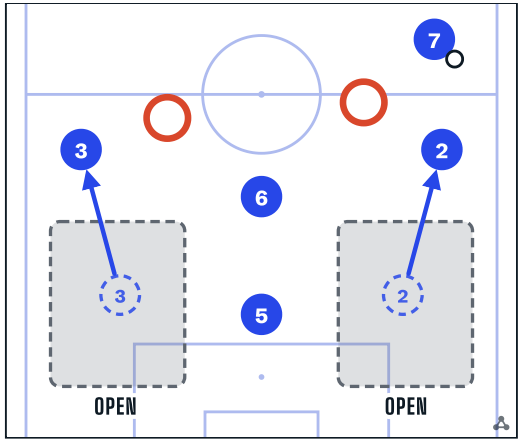
✓ RIGHT



2 goes. 3, 5 and 6 protect us.

NEVER BOTH

✕ WRONG



Both go forward: both sides are open.

LOOK FOR

Ball on the right: 2 goes; 3, 5 and 6 protect us.

Ball on the left: 3 goes; 2, 5 and 6 protect us.

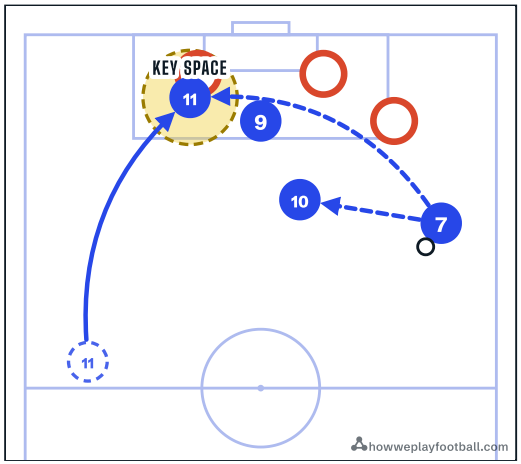
Staying means moving inside a little, next to 5.

IF THE OTHER DEFENDER GOES, YOU STAY.

03 FAR SIDE IN

When we attack down one side, the opposite wide player attacks the goal.

ATTACK DOWN THE RIGHT



7 has the ball. 9 keeps their defenders busy. 10 supports. 11 gets in at the far post.

LOOK FOR

Down the left it mirrors: 11 has the ball and 7 gets in at the far post.

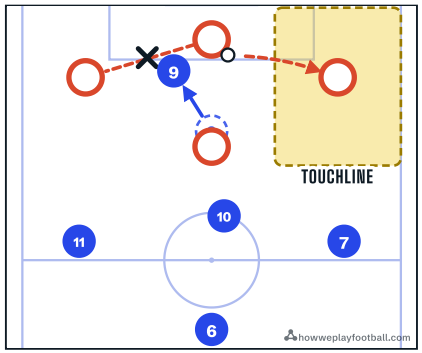
Not one striker: three players who can score.

BALL ON YOUR SIDE: GIVE US WIDTH. BALL ON THE OTHER SIDE: ATTACK THE GOAL.

04 SHOW THEM WIDE, THEN GO

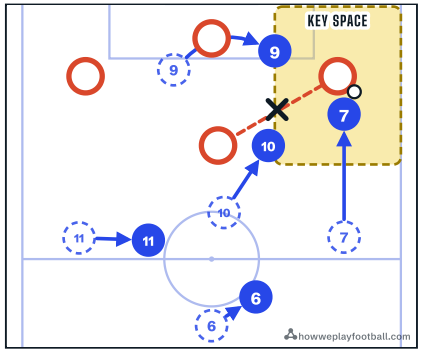
Protect the middle, guide them to the touchline, then press together.

1 · SHOW THEM WIDE



9 curves the run. The pass across or through the middle gets hard. The pass wide looks easy.

2 · GO!



7 presses. 10 blocks the pass inside. 9 blocks the pass back. 6 protects behind. Everyone shifts across.

LOOK FOR

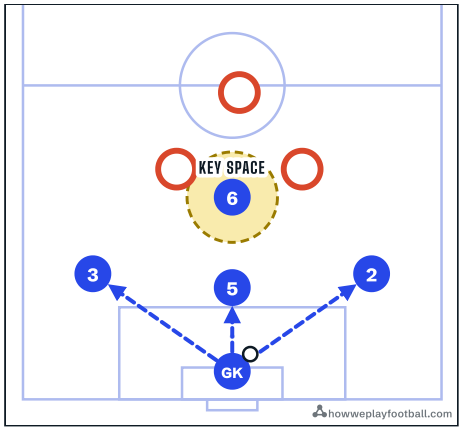
Go means the nearest players press together. It doesn't mean everyone charges at the ball.

THE TOUCHLINE HELPS US DEFEND.

GK GOALKEEPER

Start us playing

- With the ball: short to 3, 5 or 2. The 6 is available in the middle, just ahead.
- Without it: talk. Left. Right. Man on. Turn. Drop.



WITH THE BALL

Short to 3, 5 or 2. 6 is available in the middle, just ahead.

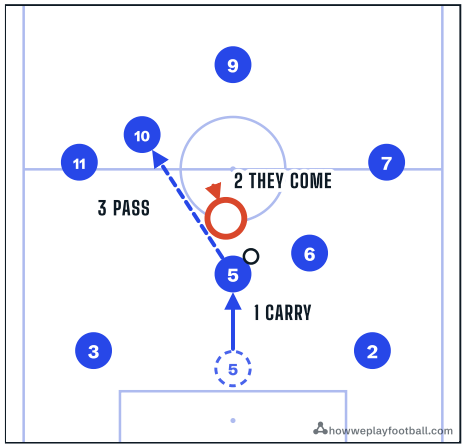
PITCH-SIDE CUE

LOOK SHORT FIRST. IF IT ISN'T ON, DON'T FORCE IT.

5 CENTRE-BACK

Keep us secure

- Protect the middle.
- Don't get dragged out unless somebody covers you.
- If nobody presses you, carry the ball forward.



CARRY, THEN PASS

1. Space ahead? Carry it forward.
2. Sooner or later an opponent has to come to you.
3. Now a teammate is free. Pass.

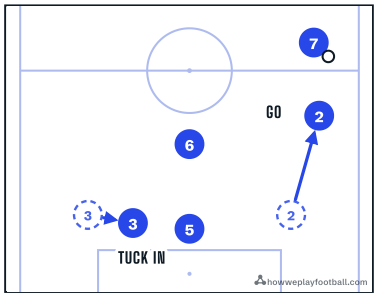
PITCH-SIDE CUE

CAN I STEP IN?

2 · 3 OUTSIDE DEFENDERS

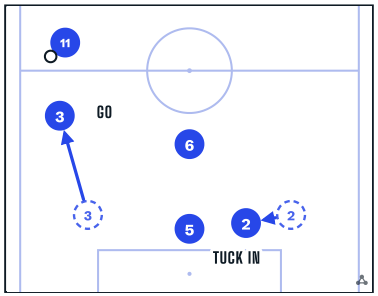
Defend first. Support second.

- Your jobs, in order: defend, help us build, join the attack.
- Ball right: 2 can go forward. 3 tucks in, almost another centre-back.
- Ball left: 3 can go forward. 2 tucks in, almost another centre-back.



BALL RIGHT

2 can go forward. 3 tucks in, almost another centre-back.



BALL LEFT

3 can go forward. 2 tucks in, almost another centre-back.

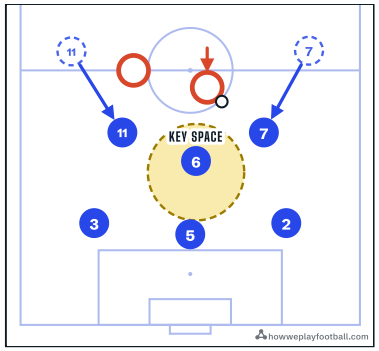
PITCH-SIDE CUE

ONE GOES. ONE STAYS.

6 THE SCREEN

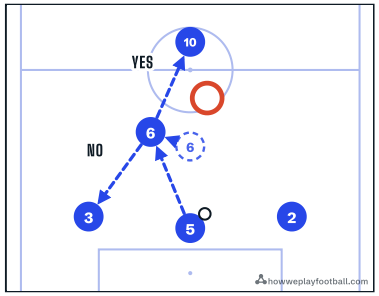
Protect. Connect.

- Stay underneath the ball. Stay central.
- Show for possession. Protect us when we lose it.



THEY BREAK AT US

Get between the attacker and 5. Slow them down, teammates recover, we defend together.



WE WIN IT BACK

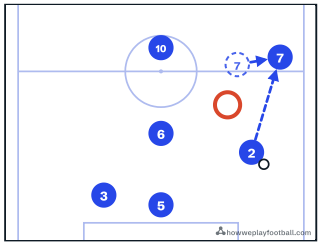
Move to find an angle, then ask: can I turn? Yes: look forward. No: play safely and move again.

PITCH-SIDE CUE

YOU DON'T HAVE TO WIN EVERY TACKLE. SOMETIMES STOPPING THEM GOING FORWARD IS ENOUGH.

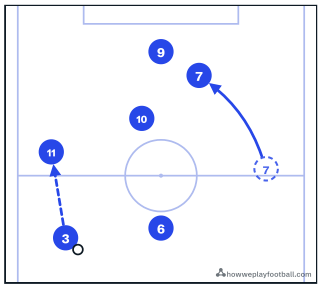
7 · 11 WIDE PLAYERS

Wide when it's ours. Narrow when it isn't.



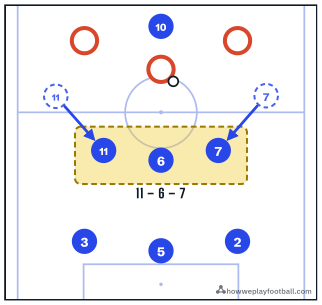
BALL ON YOUR SIDE

move wide. Give the player on the ball an easy pass.



BALL ON THE OTHER SIDE

move inside. Attack the goal.



THEY HAVE THE BALL

recover towards the centre first. Help protect the middle, in a line with the 6.

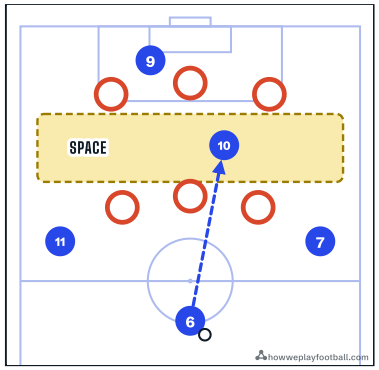
PITCH-SIDE CUE

WHERE'S THE BALL? THAT TELLS YOU WHERE TO GO.

10 NUMBER 10

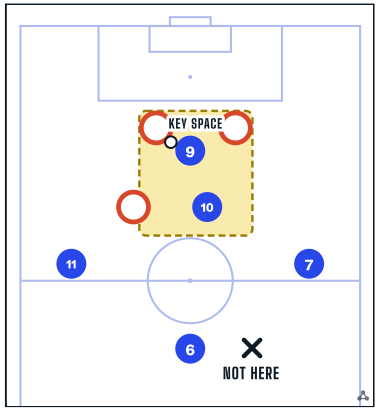
Find the space

- Find pockets of space.
- Look forward when you receive.
- You're not just a dribbler. You connect midfield and attack.
- Get close enough to support 9.
- Help us press when we lose it.



WITH THE BALL

Find pockets of space between their lines. Get close enough to support 9.



WHEN WE DEFEND

Stay close to 9 so you can press together. Don't drop all the way back next to 6.

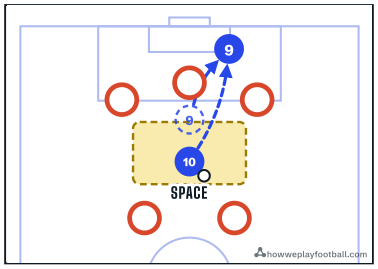
PITCH-SIDE CUE

CAN I RECEIVE FACING THEIR GOAL?

9 STRIKER

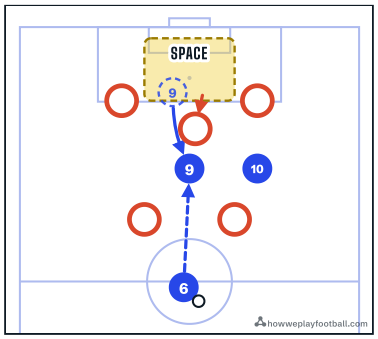
Give us somewhere to play

- Stretch the defence.
- Protect the ball when needed.
- Know when to come short and when to run behind.
- Give us a forward pass.
- Start our press.



RUN BEHIND

9 threatens the space behind. Their defenders drop, and space opens for 10.



COME SHORT

9 checks towards the ball. A defender follows, and space opens behind.

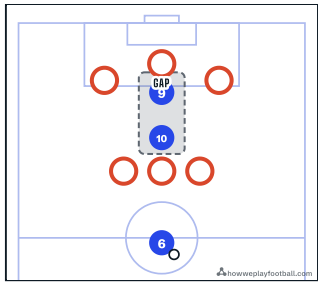
PITCH-SIDE CUE

BOTH MOVES MAKE SPACE FOR TEAMMATES.

PLAYING TOGETHER

PLAYING TOGETHER: 9 AND 10

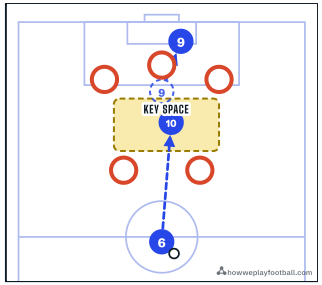
Don't stand in a line



TOO EASY

✕ WRONG

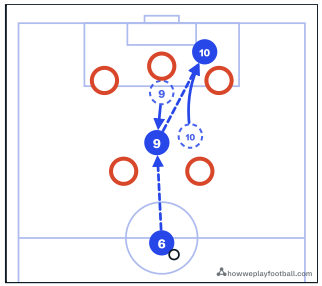
9 and 10 in the same line are easy to mark, and the pass to either is blocked.



9 RUNS, 10 RECEIVES

✓ RIGHT

9 stretches, 10 finds space.



9 COMES, 10 GOES

✓ RIGHT

one comes, one goes.

PITCH-SIDE CUE

MOVE FOR EACH OTHER.

PITCH-SIDE CUES

THE FORMATION IS OUR STARTING POSITION. IT ISN'T WHERE WE HAVE TO STAND.

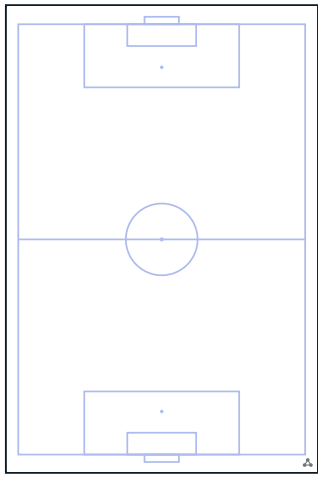
PRINCIPLES

01	**Middle first.** If you're not sure whether to go, stay central.
02	**One goes, one stays.** If the other defender goes, you stay.
03	**Far side in.** Ball on your side: give us width. Ball on the other side: attack the goal.
04	**Show them wide, then go.** The touchline helps us defend.

POSITIONS

GK	Look short first. If it isn't on, don't force it.
5	Can I step in?
2 · 3	One goes. One stays.
6	You don't have to win every tackle. Sometimes stopping them going forward is enough.
7 · 11	Where's the ball? That tells you where to go.
10	Can I receive facing their goal?
9	Both moves make space for teammates.
9 + 10	Move for each other.

NOTES



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SCAN FOR THE ONLINE GUIDE

THE 3-1-3-1 ONLINE

Animated diagrams and a page for every position.

WATCH THE 3-1-3-1 EXPLAINED

Our animated explainer, on YouTube.

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